

Athernum: The Old World

Comprehensive Rules

Copyright © 2025 Shaarigan – Schroedinger Entertainment

<https://github.com/SchroedingerEntertainment>

Athernum: The Old World and the accompanying material are licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-ShareAlike 4.0 International Public License (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0). This license allows you to copy, distribute, perform publicly, remix, modify, and build upon the work, as long as the original creator is credited, the work is not used for commercial purposes, and any changes are shared under the same license. It is valid internationally. If you intend to use the work commercially, please contact the creator.

Athernum: The Old World is based on the Archen Tactical Card Game System. This ruleset forms the mechanical foundation for cards, actions, and the game board. It has been adapted, expanded, and supplemented with original content for Athernum: The Old World in order to fully represent the unique game world and its mechanics.

Copyright © 2025 Shaarigan – Schroedinger Entertainment

<https://github.com/SchroedingerEntertainment>

The Archen Tactical Card Game System and the accompanying material are licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International Public License (CC BY 4.0). This license allows you to copy, distribute, perform publicly, remix, modify, and build upon the work as long as the original creator is credited. It is valid internationally, including for commercial purposes

Content

Athernum: The Old World

0. Core Concepts	2	7. Game Zones	32
Language Conventions	2	7.1.0 Game Board Zones	32
Rules Hierarchy and Interpretation	2	7.2.0 Secondary Board Zones	33
Definitions	3	7.3.0 Item Slots	34
Card Status	3	7.4.0 Hidden Zones	34
Resources & Mechanics	3	7.5.0 Special Notes	35
Stack & Effects	4	8. Game Setup	36
Zones & Rules	4	9. Turn Structure	37
Additional Terms	5	9.1.0 Morning Phase	37
1. Card Elements	6	9.2.0 Day Phase	38
1.1.0 Card Name	6	9.3.0 Combat Phase	40
1.2.0 Faction Symbol	7	9.4.0 Evening Phase	41
1.3.0 Effect Text	7	9.5.0 Night Phase	42
1.4.0 Characteristics (Type Line)	7	10. Marker Rules	42
1.5.0 Victory Token Field	8	10.1.0 Victory Tokens	43
1.6.0 Extra Rule Field	8	10.2.0 Command Tokens	44
1.7.0 QR-Code	9	10.3.0 Damage Counters	44
2. Card Types	9	10.4.0 Exhaustion Counters	44
2.1.0 Card Type Overview	9	10.5.0 Custom Marker Types	45
2.2.0 Character	12	11. Tournament Rules	45
2.3.0 Items	14	11.1.0 Match Rules	47
2.4.0 Locations	15	11.2.0 Card Legality and Banned Lists	48
2.5.0 Tokens	16	11.3.0 Code of Conduct	48
3. Main Character	17	11.4.0 Registration, Companion App and Online Integration	49
4. Abilities and Effects	19	12. Special Rules and Clarifications	50
4.1.0 Stack and Effect Resolution	19	12.1.0 Rule Clarifications	50
4.2.0 State-Based Checks	20	12.2.0 Extra Rules	50
4.3.0 Types of Abilities	22	A. Unique	50
4.4.0 Effect Conflicts and Modifiers	27		
5. Resources	28		
6. States and Visibility	30		
		6.1.0 Face-Down State	30
		6.2.0 Exhausted Permanents	30
		6.3.0 Copied Face-Down Permanents	31

0. Core Concepts

The Comprehensive Rules of Athernum: The Old World serve as the definitive and detailed rules reference for advanced players, judges, and tournament organizers. While the rulebook offers a structured introduction for new players, the Comprehensive Rules provide precise, exhaustive explanations of every interaction, timing window, and card type used in official play.

This document is not designed to teach the game from scratch. Instead, it assumes a working knowledge of the basic rulebook and terminology. Where discrepancies arise, card text always overrides the Comprehensive Rules.

The document does not include set-specific rulings, strategy tips, or errata. Official rulings, ban lists, and clarifications may be issued separately through organized play channels

Language Conventions

- The word "you" always refers to the controller of a card or effect
- The term "your opponent" refers to any other player in a match
- Cards, Marker and Tokens are referred to using neutral pronouns (e.g., "it," "its effects")
- All numbers and keywords appearing in quotation marks (e.g., "create," "discard") refer to rules-defined game actions or effects
- When referencing cards, their full name should be used to avoid ambiguity

Rules Hierarchy and Interpretation

- Card text takes precedence over any written rule in this document
- If two cards or effects contradict each other, the one with the most recent timestamp (i.e., the one that entered play more recently) takes precedence unless otherwise stated
- In the event of a rule conflict or ambiguity, judges are expected to interpret interactions consistently with the spirit and structure of the Comprehensive Rules
- If an interaction is not covered by this document or the core rulebook, it should be resolved by tournament staff using best judgment until an official clarification is provided

Definitions

- **Permanent** – Any face-up character, item, or location card or token that remains on the game board
- **Attachment** – A card that is attached to a permanent
- **Linked Target** – The permanent to which an attachment is linked
- **Item Slot** – A designated slot on a permanent where an attachment may be placed
- **Faction** – A player's affiliation, determined by their chosen main character
- **Main Character** – The card chosen to represent an important person in each game. Defines initiative and influences resource generation
- **Victory Token Field** – A specific field on a card that qualifies it as a potential main character
- **Ownership** – The original player to whom a card belongs, regardless of who currently controls it

Card Status

- **Face-Up** – The card is visible and its full properties are active
- **Face-Down** – The card is hidden and considered blank, retaining only its supertype
- **Exhausted** – The permanent is turned face-down and receives an exhaustion counter. It loses abilities, OFV, DFV, and subtypes, but retains its name, item slots, Victory Token Field, and all tokens or counters on it

Resources & Mechanics

- **Resource Token** – A permanent token placed into the resource zone that may be exhausted to add a resource to the pool
- **Resource Pool** – A temporary reserve of resources that empties at the end of each phase
- **Command Token** – A core resource used to pay for special abilities
- **Command Ability** – An activated ability that requires a command token as an additional cost

- **Activation Fee** – The extra cost required to activate a support ability
- **Support Ability** – An activated ability used from the hand by discarding the card and paying the activation fee

Stack & Effects

- **Stack** – The area where effects are placed and resolved in order
- **Effect** – The result of an ability or rule, such as placing tokens, moving cards, or dealing damage
- **Triggered Ability** – An ability that automatically activates in response to a game event
- **Activated Ability** – An ability manually declared and paid for
- **Static Ability** – An always-active ability that applies as long as its condition is fulfilled
- **Objective Ability** – A triggered or activated ability with the "objective" keyword that defines an alternative win condition
- **Equipment Ability** – An ability type only active on face-up attachments placed into item slots
- **Replacement Effect** – An effect that modifies or replaces another game event
- **Prevention Effect** – An effect that prevents damage or another outcome
- **State-Based Check** – A game rule check that evaluates the current state after stack resolution and at phase transitions
- **Check** – A rule-driven evaluation to determine if certain conditions are met

Zones & Rules

- **Game Board** – The shared play area where all game zones are arranged and interactions occur
- **Zone** – An area where cards, tokens, or markers may exist during the game (e.g. hand, discard pile, the void)
- **Discard** – To move a card to the discard pile from another zone

- **Return** – To move a card from a given public zone back to its owner's hand. This defaults to the game board, if no other zone was specified
- **Create** – To place a new token, marker, or resource into the game
- **Prevent** – To stop damage or another outcome from taking effect
- **Heal** – To remove damage counters from a permanent
- **Draw** – To take the top card of a deck and place it into the controlling player's hand
- **Shuffle** – To randomly reorder the contents of a deck or zone while keeping them hidden
- **Reveal** – To show a hidden card, token or hand to all players as instructed by an effect or rule
- **Search** – To look into the cards and tokens of certain zones and pick an amount of them as instructed by the conditions of an effect or rule (e.g., a player's deck for a character with a given faction)
- **Token** – A temporary, generated game element that has no card back
- **Counter** – A marker placed on a permanent representing a number or status
- **Discard Pile** – A public zone where discarded cards are placed. Visible to both players
- **The Void** – A separate zone for cards removed from the game. Cards in the void cannot be returned unless stated

Additional Terms

- **Action** – Anything of either playing a card, activation of an ability, or generating a resource performed by a player during their turn
- **Ability** – A defined function on a card or obtained by an effect, that produces an effect when used. May have costs or timing restrictions
- **Target / Targeting** – To choose a specific card, token, or marker as the focus of an effect
- **Legal Target** – A card, token, or marker that satisfies all requirements for an effect or ability when it resolves
- **Unique** – A unique card may only appear once per deck, including the Extra Deck

- **Initiative** – Determines which player takes the first turn, based on the value of the chosen main character
- **Extra Deck** – A secondary deck with up to 20 cards, each with an extra rule field, that may be referenced or obtained via condition or extra rule
- **Starting Hand** – The initial set of cards drawn at game start. Players do not redraw unless instructed by an effect
- **Active Player** – The player whose turn is currently in progress. Only the active player may perform certain actions during specific steps of their turn

1. Card Elements

Each card in Athernum: The Old World follows a unified structure consisting of core elements. These elements are present on every card regardless of card type, and are used to define a card's identity, faction, abilities, and interaction with the game system

1.1.0 Card Name

1.1.1 A card's name is its primary identifier. Cards with the same name are considered to be the same card for all game-related interactions

1.1.2 The card name appears at the top edge of the card

1.1.3 Effects that reference a card "by name" (e.g., name a card other than this card) refer to this printed name

1.1.4 If an effect refers to "this card," it references the current card in its current (possibly modified) state

1.1.5 When prompted to name a card, only official card names from the game's card database may be used

1.1.6 A token's name is determined by the effect that creates it. If no name is specified, the name defaults to its characteristics followed by "Token" (e.g., "Mechanical Construct Token")

1.1.7 If a game effect asks for a card "with the same name," this refers to the printed name. Modified characteristics (such as due to temporary effects) do not change a card's name

1.1.8 All name-based comparisons and references are based on the English version of the card name as listed in the official database

1.2.0 Faction Symbol

- 1.2.1 A card may belong to one faction or be factionless
- 1.2.2 The faction symbol is located in the top-right corner of the card
- 1.2.3 It serves as the primary indicator of the card's faction
- 1.2.4 The color and style of the card frame decoration provides a secondary visual indicator
- 1.2.5 Cards sharing the same symbol are considered part of the same faction

1.3.0 Effect Text

- 1.3.1 Each card has one or more effects, abilities, or passive rules written in the text box
- 1.3.2 The effect text defines how the card interacts with other cards, players, and game systems
- 1.3.3 The text is the authoritative source of the card's functionality and takes precedence over general rules in case of conflict
- 1.3.4 Errata published in the official card database may modify a card's printed functionality

1.4.0 Characteristics (Type Line)

- 1.4.1 The type line contains the card's supertype (e.g., Item, Location) and optionally one or more subtypes
- 1.4.2 The type line is located at the bottom-right corner of the card
- 1.4.3 Character cards do not use a printed supertype. Their card layout and mechanics inherently define them as Character cards
- 1.4.4 Supertypes define a card's broad classification (such as Item or Location) and may be referenced by other game effects. Subtypes further categorize cards and may interact with synergy effects
- 1.4.5 A token's characteristics are defined by the effect that creates it. If the effect defines a token by name and characteristics, those characteristics define the token's behavior. If the name is omitted, it defaults to the characteristics followed by "Token"

1.4.6 If a card gains a new type through a modifier that causes it to “become” a different type, it loses all previous types unless otherwise specified

1.4.7 If a card gains an additional type without the “becomes” clause, it retains its original type(s) unless a rule or effect specifically removes them

1.5.0 Victory Token Field

1.5.1 Some cards, usually Character or Location cards, have a Victory Token field

1.5.2 The field is located centered along the bottom edge of the card and is typically highlighted in gold

1.5.3 When a card with a Victory Token field is played, it increases the global Victory Token pool by the number printed in the field

1.5.4 Removing such a card from play does not reduce the global pool

1.5.5 A player may never control more than one copy of a card with a Victory Token Field at a time. This includes cards on the game board and the starting card (e.g., the main character)

1.5.6 Cards with Victory Token Fields are considered unique. If a player already controls a copy, they may not play or gain control of another

1.5.7 If a player would gain control of a second copy of a card with a Victory Token Field they already control, the effect or action is considered illegal and must be reversed or ignored

1.6.0 Extra Rule Field

1.6.1 Some cards feature a keyworded rule and a short rules text in a separate, prominent bar directly under the card name

1.6.2 The keyword is visually highlighted and represents a unique mechanic or behavior

1.6.3 Additional rules or conditions may be given in the text that follows the keyword

1.6.4 The keyword in the extra rule field functions as a shorthand for a longer rules interaction. If a rule or effect references the keyword, it applies to all cards with that extra rule field

1.7.0 QR-Code

1.7.1 Each physical card includes a QR-Code beneath a thin scratch-off layer, located in the lower-left corner of the card

1.7.2 The QR-Code serves as a unique identifier or serial number

1.7.3 Scanning the QR-Code using the companion app or a camera-enabled device allows access to:

- a. Set information, rarity, and ownership data
- b. Card-specific rulings, clarifications, or updates (errata)

1.7.4 In digital tournaments, the QR-Code provides verification of card ownership and may be required for sanctioned play. This requirement does not apply to physical tournaments unless pre-registration systems specify it

1.7.5 The QR-Code may not be copied, reproduced, or used across multiple cards. It is permanently linked to a single physical card, and its use is considered related to online activities

2. Card Types

Each card in Athernum: The Old World belongs to a specific card type. These types define how the card functions in the game, what zones it interacts with, and what characteristics it possesses. This chapter explains the distinct categories of cards, along with the core rules associated with each

2.1.0 Card Type Overview

Cards and tokens in Athernum: The Old World fall into one of three broad categories. The card type determines how a card can be played, what zones it can occupy, and how it interacts with other cards and effects:

2.1.1 **Permanents** are all cards and tokens that are typically placed in one of the three board zones: character slots, the location slot, or the resource zone

2.1.1a Permanents typically include Character and Location cards

2.1.1b Permanents also include resource and other tokens created in the appropriate zones

2.1.1c Permanents are usually played face-up in their respective zones unless an effect states otherwise

2.1.1d Only permanents can become exhausted

2.1.1e Only permanents can enter and remain on the game board under normal game rules. If an effect attempts to put a non-permanent on the board, it fails unless that effect explicitly overrides the rule

2.1.1f A permanent is considered to have "entered the game board" when it is legally placed into the appropriate zone from any other zone, including the hand, or as the result of an effect

2.1.2 **Attachments** are all cards and tokens that typically do not exist independently on the game board but must be placed into an item slot of a valid target

2.1.2a Attachments must be linked to a valid target with an available item slot

2.1.2a.I Attachments typically include Item cards that are attached to a target

2.1.2a.II Attachments also include tokens created directly into an available item slot

2.1.2b Attachments may be placed face-up or face-down

2.1.2c Only the controller of the linked target may look at face-down attachments unless a rule or effect states otherwise

2.1.2d A face-down attachment may be turned face-up at any time the controller of the linked target has priority

2.1.2e If the linked target leaves the game board or the attachment becomes unattached for any reason and cannot immediately be reassigned, the attachment is discarded

2.1.2f Attachments cannot exist on the game board unattached unless an effect allows it

2.1.2g Face-up attachments may be discarded at any time by the controller of the linked target, if they have priority

2.1.2h An attached item continues to apply its effects as long as it remains linked and face-up, unless an effect says otherwise

2.1.3 Tokens are temporary instances of permanents or attachments that are not part of a player's deck

2.1.3a A token is always owned by the player controlling the effect it was created by and is controlled by that player unless an effect changes control

2.1.3b Tokens may represent characters, items, or locations and follow the rules associated with their type

2.1.3c Abilities and values of character tokens are defined solely by the effect that created them and remain fixed unless explicitly modified

2.1.3d Tokens are created in the appropriate zone depending on their type (e.g., a character token in an empty character slot)

2.1.3e Tokens cease to exist when they leave the zone they were created in. They can never be part of any player's deck, hand, or discard pile

2.1.3f Tokens do not have a card back and are not treated as cards for the purposes of deck construction

2.1.3g A token is not a card, and effects or rules that refer to cards do not apply to tokens unless explicitly stated

2.1.4 Value Tokens are a special type of permanent token that are not part of a player's deck

2.1.4a Value tokens are always created in and may only exist in the Resource Zone. They cannot be created in any other zone

2.1.4b Value tokens are considered permanents and follow all general rules for tokens

2.1.4c Any number of value tokens may exist simultaneously. There is no upper limit on the number of value tokens a player may control

2.1.5 Whenever an effect refers to a "permanent", it includes any card or token in one of the 3 zones: character slots, location slot and resource zone

2.1.6 Whenever an effect refers to an "attachment", it includes any card or token legally occupying an item slot

2.1.7 Whenever an effect refers to a "token", it includes any temporary instance of a permanent or attachment that is not part of a player's deck

2.2.0 Character

Character cards represent important individuals or beings in the world of Athernum: The Old World.

2.2.1 Character cards are the only card type that possesses an acquisition cost

2.2.1a The acquisition cost is shown in the upper right corner of the card

2.2.1b A character's acquisition cost indicates how many resources must be spent to play the character from hand

2.2.1c If the character belongs to a faction, at least one of the resources spent must match that faction

2.2.2 Characters with item slots are valid linked targets for attachments

2.2.2a Item slots are located above the QR-Code on the left edge of the card

2.2.2b The number of item slots determines how many attachments may be linked to the same character at any time

2.2.2c The number of item slots a character has can be modified by effects. If the number of occupied slots exceeds the new limit, no attachments are discarded unless an effect or rule explicitly causes it

2.2.3 Every character has an Offensive Value, also known as their attack value, which defines how much base damage they can deal

2.2.3a The Offensive Value is displayed in a red field at the bottom edge of the card

2.2.3b The interpretation of this value may vary by card theme – it may represent physical strength, mechanical power, force, or precision

2.2.3c A character without an offensive value is treated as having 0 attack

2.2.3d Any permanent with an offensive value can be declared as an attacker

2.2.3e This value defines how many damage counters a permanent deals when attacking

2.2.3f The effective Offensive Value of a permanent cannot be less than 0. If a value lower than 0 is calculated, it is treated as 0

2.2.4 Every character has a Defensive Value, also known as their defense value, which defines how much damage they can take before being discarded

2.2.4a The Defensive Value is displayed in a blue field at the bottom edge of the card

2.2.4b The interpretation of this value may vary by card theme – it may represent health, armor, shielding, or durability

2.2.4c A character without a defensive value is treated as having 0 defense

2.2.4d Any permanent with a defensive value may be declared as a blocker

2.2.4e Damage counters may be placed on any permanent with a defensive value

2.2.4f If the number of damage counters on a permanent is equal to or greater than its current defensive value, that permanent is discarded during the next state-based check

2.2.4g The effective Defensive Value of a permanent cannot be less than 0. If a value lower than 0 is calculated, it is treated as 0

2.2.5 The combined Offensive- and Defensive Value is summarized as a permanent's "combat stat". They usually appear in the Format {OFV}{DFV} (e.g., a 1|1 character)

2.2.6 Modifiers that change a permanent's Offensive or Defensive Value are applied in the following order: base value, continuous effects, then temporary effects. The current value is recalculated during each state-based check

2.2.6a Effects that modify a permanent's Offensive or Defensive Value apply regardless of whether the source of the effect is an ability, static effect, or triggered ability. All modifications are additive unless specified otherwise

2.2.7 If a character with item slots is discarded or otherwise removed from the game board, all attachments linked to it are discarded unless an effect prevents this

2.2.8 Character cards with a Victory Token Field are subject to being semi-unique

2.2.8a Each player may control only one copy of a specific character card with a Victory Token Field at a time

2.2.8b A player may not play a character card with a Victory Token Field if they already control a copy of that card

2.2.8c If a player somehow controls more than one copy of such a card, all but one must be discarded during the next state-based check

2.2.8d Permanents that violate this rule do not contribute to the Victory Token Pool and do not trigger any related effects during state-based checks

2.2.8e If an effect attempts to create a token that would violate this rule, the token is not created, and any part of the effect related to that token is negated. All other parts of the effect resolve as normal

2.2.8f This restriction also applies to face-down cards or cards that have lost their character type but retain a Victory Token Field

2.2.8g This restriction still applies if the card has lost its character type or has become a different type due to continuous effects

2.2.8h If a permanent that was originally a character card becomes a different type, such as an item or location, it still counts as the same card for purposes of uniqueness if it retains a Victory Token Field

2.3.0 Items

Item cards represent equipment, tools, or artifacts that can be used by characters during gameplay. They offer various abilities and effects depending on how they are played

2.3.1 Item cards can be played directly

2.3.1a Item cards can be played without additional costs

2.3.1b Their static effects are immediately placed on the stack, and the card is then discarded

2.3.2 Item cards can be attached to a character

2.3.2a Items may be attached to an available item slot of a valid linked target controlled by the item's owner

2.3.2b Attached items remain on the game board until discarded by the controller of the linked target, removed by effects, or the linked target leaving their zone

2.3.2c An item may only be placed into an available item slot

2.3.2d Items may be attached face-up. Their static effects are placed on the stack immediately

2.3.2e Items may be attached face-down. Their static effects are placed on the stack once the item is turned face-up

2.3.2f A face-up item may also trigger or activate abilities as long as it remains in the item slot

2.3.2g If the linked target leaves the game board or the item becomes unattached for any reason and cannot immediately be reassigned, it is discarded

2.4.0 Locations

Location cards represent important sites, strongholds, or settings within the world of Athernium. They offer strategic advantages and effects that influence gameplay

2.4.1 Location cards can be played without additional costs

2.4.2 Only one location may be played per turn

2.4.3 Locations are placed into the player's location slot

2.4.4 Each player may control only one location at a time

2.4.4a Only the most recently placed location remains in play. This also applies to tokens

2.4.4b All other locations controlled by the player are discarded during the next state-based check

2.4.4c Their static effects are immediately placed on the stack unless they enter the game board exhausted

2.4.4d This restriction also applies to face-down permanents or permanents that have lost their location type

2.4.4e This restriction still applies if the permanent has lost its location type or has become a different type due to continuous effects

2.4.4f If a permanent that was originally a location becomes a different type, such as an item or character, it still counts as the same permanent for purposes of this rule

2.4.5 Locations with item slots are valid linked targets for attachments

2.4.5a Item slots are located above the QR-Code on the left edge of the card

2.4.5b A location without any item slots is treated as having 0 item slots

2.4.5c The number of item slots determines how many attachments may be linked to the same location at any time

2.4.5d The number of item slots a location has can be modified by effects. If the number of occupied slots exceeds the new limit, no attachments are discarded unless an effect or rule explicitly causes it

2.4.6 If a location with item slots is discarded or otherwise removed from the game board, all attachments linked to it are discarded unless an effect prevents this

2.4.7 Only a face-up location may trigger or activate abilities

2.5.0 Tokens

Tokens are temporary game elements created by effects during gameplay. Although they are not part of a player's deck, they interact with the game board and rules similarly to cards

2.5.1 Tokens may be created as permanents or attachments, and must always be created into a valid zone or item slot

2.5.2 Tokens are treated as permanents or attachments while on the board and follow all rules applicable to those types

2.5.3 A token ceases to exist when it leaves the board or the zone it was created in

2.5.4 Tokens cannot move to a player's hand, deck, discard pile or the void unless an effect explicitly states otherwise. If such a move would occur without a valid rule or effect, the token is removed from the game instead

2.5.5 Tokens can have any type or subtype (e.g., character, item, location) assigned by the effect that creates them

2.5.6 Tokens are not cards and do not have a card back. They may not be used for deck construction or shuffled into any pile

2.5.7 If a token would be affected by an effect that applies only to cards, it is unaffected unless explicitly stated

2.5.8 A token is considered to have the name assigned to it by the effect that created it. If no name is specified, the name defaults to its characteristics followed by "Token"

3. Main Character

Each game of Athernum: The Old World begins with the selection of a main character. This card represents the identity and faction of a player and anchors several core rules throughout the game

3.0.1 Every deck must include at least one card with a Victory Token Field

3.0.1a The card must be a permanent or be legally able to exist as a permanent on the game board

3.0.1b The card must not be prevented from existing on the game board by a rule or effect

3.0.1c If the card is an item, it must be allowed by a special rule to enter the game board as a permanent

3.0.2 Before the game starts, each player secretly selects one eligible card with a Victory Token Field from their deck

3.0.2a The chosen card is placed face down into the main character zone

3.0.2b Once all players have completed their setup, they reveal their main character

3.0.2c The player with the main character that has the highest initiative starts the game

3.0.2c.I Initiative is determined by the acquisition cost

3.0.2c.II If the card has no acquisition cost, its initiative is considered to be 0

3.0.2c.III The lower the acquisition cost, the higher the initiative. The highest initiative wins

3.0.2c.IV In case of a tie, a random method (e.g., coin toss or die roll) determines the starting player

3.0.3 If the chosen card is a character, it is placed in the main character zone. Otherwise, it is placed in its appropriate game zone, and the main character zone remains unused

3.0.4 All main characters enter the game exhausted but without receiving an exhaustion counter. The exhausted state must still be visibly indicated

3.0.5 The main character is treated as a permanent on the game board, but is subject to special rules. These rules override any general rule unless otherwise specified

3.0.6 The selected main character determines the player's faction

3.0.6a If the main character is factionless, the player has no faction

3.0.6b If an effect refers to a player's faction, it refers to the faction of their main character

3.0.6c If an effect refers to cards of the player's faction, it refers to cards of the same faction. If the player has no faction, it refers to factionless cards

3.0.6c.I The same applies to references to permanents or attachments of the player's faction

3.0.6d When the command ability "Solvency" is used to create a resource token, the token matches the player's faction

3.0.7 The selected main character may not leave its zone

3.0.7a The main character may not be moved to any other zone such as the hand, deck, discard pile, or the void

3.0.7b The main character may not be discarded or otherwise removed by any action or effect

3.0.7c If the semi-uniqueness rule applies, the main character may not be chosen or discarded

3.0.7c.I Nevertheless, the semi-uniqueness rule still applies

3.0.7d Control of the main character cannot be changed by any action or effect

3.0.7e If the main character has damage counters equal to or greater than its Defensive Value during a state-based check, it is not discarded

3.0.7e.I Instead, the main character becomes exhausted

3.0.7e.II All damage counters on it are removed

3.0.7e.III All attachments, counters, and other statuses remain in place

4. Abilities and Effects

In Athernum: The Old World, abilities and effects form the foundation of most interactions between cards, players, and the game board. While each card may contain text describing its effects, these effects interact with the game environment through a consistent system that revolves around the stack and regular state-based checks. Understanding this structure is essential for resolving gameplay correctly

4.1.0 Stack and Effect Resolution

In Athernum: The Old World, cards themselves are never placed on the stack. Only their effects are added to the stack and resolved in order. This rule allows for a clear interaction flow and avoids the need to reverse actions involving cards themselves

4.1.1 Only the active player can play cards

4.1.2 Only a player who has priority can turn attachments face-up or activate or trigger abilities

4.1.3 Whenever a card is played, an attachment is turned face-up, or an ability is triggered or activated – and no stack currently exists – a new empty stack is created

4.1.4 Whenever a card is played or an attachment is turned face-up, its static effects are put onto the stack:

4.1.4a If that card or attachment has static abilities, these effects are placed on the stack

4.1.4b A static effect is immediate when it does not change or modify the overall game state (e.g., "Draw a card")

4.1.4c A static effect is continuous when it changes or modifies the overall game state (e.g., "Characters get +1 OFV")

4.1.4c.I These effects are placed on the stack only once

4.1.4c.II If such an effect is modified or neutralized, it keeps that state until it is placed on the stack again

4.1.5 Whenever an ability is triggered or activated, its effects are put onto the stack

4.1.6 Once a stack exists, other players may gain priority to respond to an effect with additional effects

4.1.7 Once all players pass priority without adding further effects, the stack resolves from top to bottom (Last In, First Out)

4.1.8 Effects on the stack can be modified or neutralized before they resolve

4.1.8a An effect can modify or neutralize only effects previously put onto the same stack

4.1.8b An effect is considered modified if its outcome is changed by another rule or effect, such as a redirection, replacement, or value change

4.1.8c An effect that is modified keeps its modified state until it resolves, unless it is modified again

4.1.8d An effect that is neutralized is removed from the stack entirely before it can resolve

4.1.9 Some abilities or effects impose temporary restrictions on other permanents, attachments or even players, such as “may not attack during its controller’s next turn”

4.1.9a When such an effect resolves, it creates a temporary restriction state on the affected targets

4.1.9b A restriction state remains in effect until it is reset or the affected permanent or attachment leaves its current zone

4.1.9c The duration of a restriction state is determined by the wording of the effect that create it and reset at the specific time defined, such as at the end of the current turn or when the controller’s next turn begins

4.1.10 Once all effects have fully resolved, the stack is closed and a state-based check is performed immediately

4.2.0 State-Based Checks

State-based checks occur automatically after the stack has been closed and before the active player regains priority. These checks maintain consistency across the game board and apply changes that are not tied to specific effects. The state-based check performs the following tasks in sequential order:

4.2.1 Apply continuous effects and rule modifications

4.2.1a Any effect with a defined duration (e.g., "until end of turn") is checked during this step. If its duration has expired, the effect ends and is no longer applied

4.2.1b If the linked target of an attachment changes, the effect persists and applies to the new target

4.2.2 Evaluate the status of all permanents on the game board and attachments, in the following order:

4.2.2a If a face-up permanent has damage counters equal to or greater than its Defensive Value, it is discarded

4.2.2b If a permanent violates the semi-uniqueness rule, the rule is resolved and those permanents are discarded

4.2.2c If a player controls more than one location, all but the most recently placed one are discarded

4.2.2d If a permanent token has left the zone it was created in, it ceases to exist and is removed from the game instead

4.2.2e If an attachment exists without a valid linked target and it cannot be reassigned, it is discarded

4.2.2f If an attachment token has left the zone it was created in, it ceases to exist and is removed from the game instead

4.2.2g If a permanent with a Victory Token Field entered the game board, an amount of Victory Tokens is added to the global pool equal to the current amount required by its Victory Token Field

4.2.2h If a face-up permanent with an Objective Ability has Victory Tokens equal to or greater than the current amount required by its Victory Token Field, its controller wins the game

4.2.3 Evaluate the overall game status, in the following order:

4.2.3a If an effect or condition causes a player to lose the game, that player loses the game

4.2.3b If an effect or condition causes a player to win the game, that player wins the game

4.2.3c A player who has collected the majority of all Victory Tokens wins the game

4.2.3d If the condition for an ability is met, that ability triggers after the state-based check completes

4.2.3d.I If an ability is identified to trigger, its effects are put onto a new stack in the next available priority window after the state-based check completes and before the active player regains priority

4.2.3d.II If an effect created a trigger scheduled for a specific point of the game, that trigger is considered independent of its source and will occur exactly once at the specified time

4.2.3d.III If a triggered ability refers to a card, permanent or attachment that caused it but has changed zones in between (e.g., a character that was just discarded), the effect still resolves

4.2.3d.IV The effect refers to the last known state of the card, permanent, or attachment that caused it to trigger (e.g., before that character was discarded)

4.2.4 Evaluate the status of players and other conditions, in the following order:

4.2.4a If a player lost the game and there are no other opponents left, the remaining player wins the game

4.2.4b If a player attempted to draw from an empty deck, that player loses the game

After the state-based check is completed, the game verifies whether any abilities were triggered. If so, the procedure repeats by creating a new stack. Otherwise, the active player receives priority.

4.3.0 Types of Abilities

In Athernium: The Old World, abilities form the foundation of most interactions. They create effects that influence cards, players, and the game state, and are divided into several distinct types

4.3.1 Each ability printed on a card or granted to permanents and attachments as the result of an effect, is treated as a separate rule entry

4.3.1a Triggered and activated abilities always resolve independently of one another, even when printed on the same card or applied to the same permanent or attachment

4.3.1b This applies equally to Equipment Abilities

4.3.2 Abilities are only accessible if the card is in a zone where that ability type may legally be used

4.3.2a Static, triggered and activated abilities usually require the permanent or attachment to be face-up on the game board

4.3.2b If an ability is granted as the result of an effect to a permanent or attachment, that ability may trigger or activate independent of that permanent's or attachment's current state, unless it changes zones

4.3.2c Some abilities may also trigger or activate when a card is in their owner's discard pile or the void

4.3.2d Some abilities may also trigger or activate when a card is face-up on the top of their owner's deck

4.3.2e Support Abilities require the card to be in their owner's hand

4.3.3 Some abilities begin with predefined keywords like Objective, Command, Support, or Equip

4.3.3a These keywords indicate specific rules governing the activation and resolution of those abilities

4.3.3b Activated abilities otherwise have unique names defined by their card text. These named abilities follow the general rules unless otherwise stated

4.3.4 Some abilities create replacement or prevention effects

4.3.4a These effects are placed on the stack like any other and resolve normally

4.3.4b Once resolved, they remain active and modify the overall game state as described, unless they were neutralized or otherwise modified

4.3.5 Each type defines how and when an ability can be used, how it interacts with the stack, and what special conditions or rules may apply:

4.3.5a **Static Abilities** are always active while the card is face-up in a valid zone

4.3.5a.I Their effects are placed on the stack once when the card enters the game board or an attachment is turned face-up

4.3.5a.II The effect no longer applies once the card is turned face-down or leaves its current zone

4.3.5b **Triggered Abilities** put their effect onto the stack when a specific condition is met. They usually start with the word “when”, “whenever”, or “at”

4.3.5b.I Triggered abilities activate automatically and place their effect on the stack after a state-based check completes

4.3.5b.II They cannot be interrupted or delayed unless otherwise specified

4.3.5b.III Effects may create triggers scheduled to occur at a later point in the game. They exist independently of the card or permanent that created them and trigger once the specified condition is met, even if the originating source has changed zones in between

4.3.5b.IV Triggered abilities may require a valid target upon resolution. If no valid target exists, the effect has no impact. If some, but not all, targets become invalid before resolution, the remaining valid targets are affected as normal

4.3.5c **Activated Abilities** always have a name written in italic text before their effect, unless they specify a keyword such as Objective, Support, or Command

4.3.5c.I They must be manually declared as active by the controller of the permanent or attachment and must be paid for immediately

4.3.5c.II Activated Abilities follow the format [Cost]: [Effect]

4.3.5c.IIa A numerical cost (e.g., {4}): [Effect]) may be paid using resources of any type, unless the ability specifies a particular type

4.3.5c.IIb If no cost is defined, the ability lacks the [Cost] component and colon

4.3.5c.IIc The ability may still be activated as long as its timing restriction is satisfied

4.3.5c.III The effects of an activated ability are placed on the stack once activated

4.3.5c.IV They resolve even if the source is turned face-down or leaves its current zone

4.3.5c.V Activated abilities may require a valid target upon resolution. If no valid target exists, the effect has no impact. If some, but not all, targets become invalid before resolution, the remaining valid targets are affected as normal

4.3.5d **Objective Abilities** are a special type of triggered or activated abilities

4.3.5d.I They always begin with the keyword Objective

4.3.5d.II Objective abilities represent the personal motivations of a permanent and interact with that permanent's Victory Token Field

4.3.5d.III Objective Abilities define alternate victory conditions that allow a player to win the game independently of collecting the majority of Victory Tokens

4.3.5e **Command Abilities** are a special type of activated abilities

4.3.5e.I They always begin with the keyword Command

4.3.5e.II Activating a command ability requires a Command Token to be used in addition to the regular cost

4.3.5f **Support Abilities** are a special type of activated abilities

4.3.5f.I Support abilities may only be activated when the active player has priority and no stack currently exists

4.3.5f.II The card is revealed, its Activation Fee is paid (located at the left, next to the top of the ability), and it is discarded as part of the cost

4.3.5f.III The effect is then placed on the stack and resolves independently of the card's later state

4.3.5f.IV Cards can only have one support ability printed on them

4.3.5g **Linked Abilities** are a special type of static, triggered or activated abilities

4.3.5g.I They are most commonly found on character cards or permanents and begin with the keyword Linked

4.3.5g.II A permanent with a linked ability defines one or more Linked Zones

4.3.5g.IIa Linked Zones are a designated set of Character Slots relative to the permanent with the linked ability

4.3.5g.IIb The relative direction of Linked Zones are visually highlighted on the border of a card or defined by the effect creating a permanent with a linked ability

4.3.5g.IIc They may include any combination of Character Slots directly to the left or right of that permanent. This also applies if the permanent is in a different zone owned by its controller (e.g., the Location Slot)

4.3.5g.IId They may also include the Character Slot directly opposite that permanent, owned by the opponents of that permanent's controller. This applies to each opponent regardless of their position at the table

4.3.5g.IIe Linked Zones are not separate zones. They remain regular character slots but gain the property of being linked while a card with the appropriate linked ability is adjacent to that slot

4.3.5g.IIf Linked Zones may overlap. If multiple linked abilities apply to the same slot, their effects accumulate

4.3.5g.IIg When a permanent with a linked ability leaves the game board, its defined Linked Zones immediately cease to exist

4.3.5g.IIh If an effect redefines the Linked Zones of a permanent, that definition takes precedence

4.3.5g.III If an effect refers to a "linked permanent", it refers to a permanent occupying one of the defined Linked Zones

4.3.5g.IV If an effect refers to a permanent being "linked to a permanent", it refers to a permanent occupying a Character Slot designated as a Linked Zone of another permanent

4.3.5g.V The source of the effect is always the permanent itself, even if the effect applies to a linked permanent

4.3.5g.VI For the purpose of rule interactions, the permanent is considered the source of any linked ability, even when the effect modifies or targets the linked permanent

4.3.5h **Equipment Abilities** are a special type of static, triggered or activated abilities

4.3.5h.I They are most commonly found on item cards or attachments and begin with the keyword Equip

4.3.5h.II Those abilities only function while the attachment is face-up in a valid item slot

4.3.5h.III Static equipment effects are placed on the stack once when the attachment enters the game board or is turned face-up, and while it remains face-up on the game board

4.3.5h.IV If an effect refers to the “equipped permanent”, it refers to the linked target

4.3.5h.V The source of the effect is always the attachment itself, even if the effect applies to the linked target

4.3.5h.VI For the purpose of rule interactions, the attachment is considered the source of any equipment ability, even when the effect modifies or targets the equipped permanent

4.3.5i Some abilities include restrictions that limit when or how often they may be used, such as “once per turn” or “only during your turn”

4.3.5i.I The activation or triggering of such an ability creates a temporary restriction state on the source of that ability

4.3.5i.II A restriction state remains in effect until it is reset or the source of the ability leaves its current zone

4.3.5i.III A restriction state is reset at the specific time defined by its restriction, such as at the end of the current turn or when the controller’s next turn begins

4.4.0 Effect Conflicts and Modifiers

In Athernium: The Old World, multiple effects may influence the same values or properties of cards, permanents and attachments. This section outlines how such conflicts are resolved, in which order different types of modifiers are applied, and how final values are determined. Understanding these rules ensures consistent gameplay, especially when complex effect combinations occur:

4.4.1 Resolving Conflicting Effects

4.4.1a If two or more effects apply to the same property but define different results (e.g., “set OFV to 3” and “set OFV to 5”), the most recent effect takes precedence

4.4.1b Effects that modify values (e.g., +1 or -2) do not conflict with set effects but are applied after the base value is established

4.4.2 Order of Application

When multiple effects apply to the same numeric property (such as Offensive Value or Defensive Value), they are resolved in the following order:

4.4.2a Effects that set a base value

4.4.2b Additive and subtractive modifiers

4.4.2c Multiplicative modifiers

4.4.2d Conditional or replacement effects

4.4.3 Result Evaluation

4.4.3a The final value is calculated using the cumulative result after all modifiers have been applied in the order above

4.4.3b If an effect modifies a property of an invalid or hidden source, that effect has no impact

5. Resources

In Athernum: The Old World, resources represent a flexible form of value used to pay for card costs and the activation of abilities. Each player has their own resource pool, which is emptied at the end of each phase. Resources are most commonly produced by exhausting resource tokens, but may also be generated by certain effects

5.0.1 Resource Tokens and the Resource Zone

5.0.1a Resource tokens are a type of value token, placed face-up in the resource zone

5.0.1b They do not generate resources automatically but must be exhausted to do so

5.0.1c When a resource token is exhausted, it adds one resource to its controller's resource pool

5.0.1d A player may exhaust any number of resource tokens under their control at any time they have priority

5.0.1e Exhausting a resource token is not an effect and does not use the stack. It is considered part of paying a cost and does not trigger any other effects

5.0.2 Resource Token Generation

5.0.2a The command ability „Solvency” allows the active player to create one resource token once per turn

5.0.2b Like other command abilities, „Solvency” is placed on the stack and can be responded to before it resolves

5.0.2c When resolved, it creates a face-up resource token in the active player’s resource zone

5.0.3 Resource Pool and Usage

5.0.3a Resources generated (e.g., by exhausted tokens) are added to a player’s personal resource pool

5.0.3b Each resource retains the faction type defined by the token that produced it or as specified by the effect that generated it (e.g., 'Add {1}' or 'Add [Faction-Icon]')

5.0.3c If no faction is specified, the resource generated is factionless

5.0.3d A player may spend resources from their pool at any time they have priority and are paying a cost

5.0.3e Certain costs may require specific faction types, which must be matched accordingly

5.0.3f Resources can only be paid in whole units. Fractional or partial payments are not allowed

5.0.3g Paying a cost using resources is not an effect and cannot be responded to

5.0.3h Some effects may restrict or prevent the generation or usage of resources. These rules override standard generation methods

5.0.4 Resource Cleanup

5.0.4a At the end of each phase, each player’s resource pool is emptied

5.0.4b If a resource token would move to a different zone, it ceases to exist instead

6. States and Visibility

In Athernum: The Old World, permanents and attachments on the game board may be face-up, face-down, or exhausted. These states affect their visibility, properties, and interactions with effects. This chapter defines how states function and how they influence gameplay

6.1.0 Face-Down State

6.1.1 Cards may enter the game board face-down. Permanents and attachments may be turned face-down by effects or exhaustion

6.1.2 A face-down permanent or attachment loses all defining characteristics except its supertype (Character, Location or Item)

6.1.3 The supertype is determined by the zone in which the permanent or attachment is located

6.1.4 Only the controller of a face-down permanent or the controller of its linked target (in case of attachments) may look at the card

6.1.5 A face-down permanent or attachment has no abilities, values, or subtypes and is treated as blank

6.1.6 A permanent may only be turned face-up when explicitly allowed by an effect

6.1.7 Attachments may be turned face-up at any time their linked target's controller has priority

6.1.8 A card's current status only applies while it remains on the game board

6.1.8a When a card moves to a different zone, it is no longer considered face-down and/or exhausted

6.1.8b Tokens follow the same rule, unless otherwise specified

6.2.0 Exhausted Permanents

6.2.1 Only permanents can be exhausted

6.2.2 An exhausted permanent is turned face-down and marked with one exhaustion counter

6.2.3 An exhausted permanent loses the following:

6.2.3a All abilities printed on it or given by the effect it was created from (in case of a token)

6.2.3b Offensive Value (OFV) and Defensive Value (DFV)

6.2.3c Subtypes

6.2.4 It retains the following:

6.2.4a Card name

6.2.4b Extra rules

6.2.4c Item Slots

6.2.4d Victory Token Field

6.2.4e Any counters or tokens placed on it

6.2.5 Exhausted cards may be looked at by all players

6.2.6 During the Morning Phase of the active player, one exhaustion counter is removed from each exhausted permanent they control

6.2.7 If an exhausted permanent has no exhaustion counters remaining after this step, it is turned face-up

6.2.8 Effects may add or remove exhaustion counters

6.2.8a A permanent only turns face-up early if an effect explicitly allows it

6.2.9 A permanent may receive more than one exhaustion counter

6.2.9a A permanent that is already exhausted cannot be exhausted again for the purpose of paying a cost or fulfilling a rule-based requirement (such as attacking, blocking, or generating resources)

6.3.0 Copied Face-Down Permanents

6.3.1 If a permanent or attachment is copied while it is face-down, the copy is also created face-down and retains only the visible information at the time of copying

6.3.2 This includes its supertype and, its name, extra rules, item slots and Victory Token Field

6.3.3 The copy does not gain any hidden characteristics such as abilities, subtypes, or values unless defined by the copying effect

6.3.4 If such a copy is turned face-up, it retains only the information that was copied. All undefined values are treated as their default (e.g., 0 for OFV and DFV)

6.3.5 The copy remains in play unless an effect specifies otherwise

7. Game Zones

In Athernium: The Old World, all cards and tokens exist in exactly one zone at any given time. The zone determines a card's visibility, its interaction with effects, and whether it is considered in play. Cards may change zones through gameplay, but not all states or properties persist across zone changes

7.1.0 Game Board Zones

These zones represent the primary playing area for each player:

7.1.1 Main Character Slot

7.1.1a Reserved for the selected main character in case of a character card

7.1.1b If no character is chosen, this slot remains blocked. No cards may be played into, and no tokens created in it

7.1.1c Unless otherwise specified, any rule or effect that refers to a "Character Slot" also refers to this slot

7.1.2 Character Slots

7.1.2a Each player has exactly 5 character slots

7.1.2b Each slot can hold one character card or token

7.1.2c The slot a card is played to or token is created in may be freely chosen

7.1.2c.I Only an unoccupied slot may be chosen

7.1.2c.II The owner of the card played chooses a slot they own

7.1.2c.III When a card is brought onto the game board by an effect, the controller of the effect chooses a slot owned by that card's controller

7.1.2c.IV When a token is created, the controller of the effect chooses a slot owned by that token's controller

7.1.2c.V When control of a permanent changes, the controller of the effect chooses a slot owned by its new controller

7.1.2d Once a permanent occupies a slot, it cannot be rearranged unless an effect explicitly allows it

7.1.2e If all slots are occupied, that player may not play any additional character cards and character tokens cannot be created

7.1.3 **Location Slot**

7.1.3a Each player has exactly 1 location slot

7.1.3b Each slot can hold one location card or token

7.1.4 **Resource Zone**

7.1.4a Resource tokens are placed into this zone

All cards and tokens in these zones are considered permanents

7.2.0 Secondary Board Zones

These zones are part of the game board but do not contain active permanents:

7.2.1 **Discard Pile**

7.2.1a Each player has their own discard pile

7.2.1b Cards discarded by a player are placed into this zone

7.2.1c It is publicly visible and ordered; the sequence of cards matters for effects

7.2.2 **The Void**

7.2.2a Each player has their own void

7.2.2b Cards placed here are removed from the game but still visible

7.2.2c The order is not significant unless stated otherwise

7.2.3 **Deck**

- 7.2.3a Each player's deck is kept face-down
- 7.2.3b The order must not be changed except by effects
- 7.2.3c It is not publicly visible to any player unless stated otherwise
- 7.2.3d Whenever a player draws a card, the card is drawn from the top of their deck
- 7.2.3e Whenever a card effect refers to "interacting" with the top or bottom of a player's Deck, it refers to any of looking at, revealing, rearranging, or moving one or more cards. Unless otherwise stated, such interactions do not count as drawing a card

7.3.0 Item Slots

Item slots are floating zones associated with individual permanents:

- 7.3.1 They allow cards or tokens to be attached as attachments
- 7.3.2 Attachments in item slots are always linked to a target permanent
- 7.3.3 An item slot only exists as long as its host permanent exists
- 7.3.4 Whenever a host permanent leaves their zone, its item slots cease to exist and all attachments are discarded

7.4.0 Hidden Zones

These zones are not publicly visible:

7.4.1 **Hand**

- 7.4.1a A player's hand is hidden from opponents
- 7.4.1b Cards in hand may only be viewed or affected by effects
- 7.4.1c Whenever a card is drawn, it is placed in its owner's hand

7.4.2 **Extra Deck**

- 7.4.2a A special hidden zone outside the main deck
- 7.4.2b Only their owner may look at cards inside the extra deck

7.4.2c Cards in the extra deck may only be searched, played, or revealed through effects or the operation of extra rules

7.4.2d Extra rules may require certain cards to start in the extra deck and allow them to change zones directly if specific conditions are met

7.5.0 Special Notes

7.5.1 Copies of cards are always represented by tokens

7.5.2 Tokens can only exist in the zone they were created in

7.5.2a A copy only exists as long as it remains in the zone it was created in

7.5.2b If a token would change zones, it is removed from the game instead

7.5.3 Cards lose all state-based conditions (such as face-down or exhausted) when changing zones

7.5.3a A permanent or attachment that changes zones loses all stored markers and temporary states, including restrictions and limitations currently applied to it

7.5.3b Global states, such as the number of times a specific card has been played during the game, remain unaffected by this rule

7.5.4 At no time may a card exist outside of a zone

7.5.4a A card changing zones is no longer considered to be in its origin zone once the change begins

7.5.5 Effects that temporarily remove a card and return it to play must specify both actions clearly (e.g., "Move target permanent to the void, then return it to the zone it originated from")

7.5.6 If a card moves to a zone and is later returned to its previous zone, it returns to the zone it last occupied before the change, unless otherwise specified

7.5.7 An effect that changes control of a permanent or attachment from one player to another does not constitute a zone change

7.5.7a The affected permanent or attachment remains in the same zone and retains its current state (face-up or face-down), position, and all markers, tokens, or attachments on it, unless the effect explicitly states otherwise

7.5.7b If the zone on the game board has clearly defined player areas (e.g., character slots, resource zone), the permanent or attachment is moved to the

corresponding slot of the new controller without being considered to have changed zones

7.5.7c If all slots of a clearly defined play area are occupied, control of a permanent cannot change to the new controller

8. Game Setup

Before gameplay begins, players perform a structured setup sequence. This process establishes each player's identity, defines victory conditions, and prepares the battlefield for the first turn:

8.0.1 Main Character Selection

8.0.1a Each player secretly selects one card with a victory token field from their own deck to serve as their main character

8.0.1b The selected card is placed face-down into the main character slot

8.0.1c Once all players have made their selection, the cards are revealed simultaneously

8.0.1d If a selected card is not a character, it is moved to its appropriate zone instead

8.0.1e If a selected card does not qualify as a valid main character, the game cannot begin. The player must select a different valid card or forfeit the match, depending on play context

8.0.2 Initiative Determination

8.0.2a After all main characters have been revealed, the initiative order is determined by comparing their printed acquisition costs

8.0.2b The lower the cost, the higher the initiative

8.0.2c Cards without an acquisition cost are treated as having an initiative of 0 (zero)

8.0.2d In case of a tie, the tied players determine their order randomly

8.0.3 Victory Token Pool Setup

8.0.3a The number of victory tokens used in the game is equal to the sum of all printed victory token values on the revealed main characters

8.0.3b These tokens are placed into the shared victory token pool before the game begins

8.0.4 **Deck Preparation**

8.0.4a Each player shuffles their deck thoroughly

8.0.4b Other players may request that the deck be shuffled or cut again

8.0.5 **Drawing Starting Hands**

8.0.5a Each player draws six cards from the top of their deck

8.0.5b There are no rules allowing a player to redraw their hand. Instead players must keep their initial hand

8.0.6 **Begin the First Turn**

8.0.6a The player with the highest initiative begins the game by starting the first turn

8.0.6b If multiple players share the highest initiative, determine randomly among them who begins. The remaining players follow in initiative order

9. Turn Structure

Every turn in Athernum: The Old World follows a fixed sequence of phases. These phases define what actions a player may take and when specific types of effects can occur. A full turn consists of five ordered phases followed by a transitional night phase that occurs between players' turns. Unless otherwise specified, no phase may be skipped or altered. Each phase begins and ends with a state-based check to ensure game consistency and resolve continuous effects or victory conditions

9.1.0 Morning Phase

The morning phase marks the beginning of each player's turn. During this phase, permanents recover from exhaustion, command tokens are refreshed, and the battlefield is stabilized before the player gains priority.

The following steps occur in order:

9.1.1 Remove one exhaustion counter from each exhausted permanent the active player controls

9.1.2 If any exhausted permanent has no exhaustion counters remaining after this step, it is turned face-up

9.1.3 The active player's command token supply is replenished up to a maximum of two

9.1.4 A state-based check is performed

9.1.4a Any effects that reference "At the Morning Phase" may resolve. The active player has priority only for the resolution of such effects

No cards may be played and no abilities may be activated during the morning phase unless a specific effect allows it.

This phase ends after all state-based checks and pending effects have been resolved

9.2.0 Day Phase

At the beginning of the day phase, a state-based check is performed. This check may resolve triggered abilities with the "At the Day Phase" timing or handle other continuous effects. Once the check is complete, the active player receives priority and may perform any number of legal actions in any order

9.2.1 If multiple triggered abilities would resolve at the beginning of the day phase, their controller determines the order in which they are placed on the stack

The following actions may be performed during the day phase:

9.2.2 **Activate the global command ability "Acquisition"** to draw a card

9.2.2a This ability is provided by the day phase

9.2.2b The main character is considered to be the source of this ability

9.2.2c The ability remains usable even if the main character is restricted by an effect

9.2.3 **Activate the global command ability "Solvency"** to create a resource token. This ability may only be used once per turn

9.2.3a This ability is provided by the day phase

9.2.3b The main character is considered to be the source of this ability

9.2.3c The ability remains usable even if the main character is restricted by an effect

9.2.4 **Activate the global command ability "Contingency"** to place a Victory Token on a permanent the active player owns and controls. This ability may only be used once per turn

9.2.4a This ability may be activated only if the active player has fewer Victory Tokens collected than each other player

9.2.4b This ability is provided by the day phase

9.2.4c The main character is considered to be the source of this ability

9.2.4d The ability remains usable even if the main character is restricted by an effect

9.2.5 **Play a Character card** from hand by paying its costs

9.2.6 **Play a Location card** from hand. This action may only be performed once per turn

9.2.7 **Play an Item card** from hand **or attach it** to a valid permanent

9.2.8 **Turn a face-down attachment face-up**

9.2.9 **Activate any ability** (such as support, command, objective, or named abilities), provided all associated costs are paid

9.2.9a Support abilities may be activated only when the card is in their owner's hand

9.2.10 **Exhaust a resource token to add one resource** of its faction to the player's resource pool

9.2.11 **Enter the combat phase.** This action may be performed once per turn but not during the first turn of the game

The player retains priority during the day phase unless otherwise specified. Priority only changes when the player passes or when required by a rule or effect.

Before the game proceeds to the evening phase, a new empty stack is created.

9.2.12 All players may respond by activating abilities or resolving effects

9.2.13 Once the stack is empty and all players pass in succession, the game continues

This phase ends after all state-based checks and pending effects have been resolved.

9.3.0 Combat Phase

The combat phase allows the active player to engage in tactical one-on-one battles using permanents with offensive capabilities

9.3.1 Combat is optional and may only be entered once per turn, by choice of the active player during the day phase

9.3.2 Once the combat phase ends, the active player continues their day phase, retaining priority

9.3.3 At the beginning of the combat phase, a state-based check is performed

9.3.3a Any effects that reference "At the Combat Phase" may resolve

9.3.4 The active player then receives priority and may initiate one combat at a time

Each combat must be fully resolved before another may begin. The following steps are used to conduct a combat:

9.3.5 The active player chooses one of their own face-up permanents with an offensive value (OFV) to declare as the attacker

9.3.6 The active player selects a target permanent with a defensive value (DFV) under an opponent's control

9.3.6a Permanents that are face-down or exhausted but are known to possess a DFV, or could possess one based on their card type or rules context, may be chosen as valid targets

9.3.6b Permanents that never possess a defensive value, such as attachments or cards without printed DFV, may not be chosen

9.3.7 The controller of the target may choose a face-up permanent with a defensive value (DFV) under their control to act as a defender

9.3.8 A stack is opened. All players may respond with abilities or effects. Once the stack resolves, a state-based check is performed

9.3.8a If a permanent becomes unable to be attacked after an attack has already been declared, the combat continues as normal

9.3.8b If an effect explicitly ends or cancels an attack or combat, it will prevent the combat from continuing. The attacking and blocking permanents still become exhausted, but damage is prevented and abilities referring to that combat do not trigger

9.3.8c If an effect redirects an attack to another permanent, the combat continues with the new target. The attack is considered declared against the new target and any abilities of that permanent trigger accordingly

9.3.8d If an effect modifies or prevents damage from being dealt, the combat itself still resolves. Offensive values and defensive values are compared as normal but damage is reduced, prevented or redirected as instructed

9.3.9 Combat damage is dealt simultaneously unless otherwise stated:

9.3.9a The attacker deals damage to the target equal to its OFV

9.3.9a.I If the attacker is removed from play before combat resolves, it applies no damage

9.3.9a.II If the target or defender is removed from play before combat resolves, the attack has no effect, but the attacker is still exhausted and turned face-down

9.3.9b The target deals damage back to the attacker equal to its own OFV (if any)

9.3.9b.I If the target is removed from play before combat resolves, it applies no damage

9.3.9b.II If the target has no offensive value, this damage is considered 0 (zero)

9.3.9c Damage is applied as damage counters

9.3.10 Another state-based check is performed

9.3.10a A permanent that has damage counters equal to or higher than its defensive value (DFV) is discarded

9.3.11 The attacker is turned face-down and becomes exhausted

9.3.12 If a defender was declared, it is also turned face-down and becomes exhausted

The active player may repeat this process for each additional eligible attacker they control. This phase ends after all state-based checks and pending effects have been resolved

9.4.0 Evening Phase

The evening phase concludes the active player's turn. The active player may not play cards or activate abilities during this phase unless explicitly permitted by an effect or rule. Ongoing effects that trigger or resolve at this time still take place

9.4.1 At the beginning of the evening phase, a state-based check is performed

9.4.1a Any effects that reference "At the Evening Phase" may resolve. The active player retains priority only for the resolution of such effects

Once all effects have resolved and no player has further responses, the game proceeds to the night phase.

This phase ends after all state-based checks and pending effects have been resolved.

9.5.0 Night Phase

The night phase occurs between turns, after one player's evening phase has ended and before the next player's morning phase begins

9.5.1 There is no active player during the night phase

9.5.2 At the beginning of the night phase, a state-based check is performed

9.5.2a Effects with timing conditions such as "At the Night Phase" or "between turns" may resolve

9.5.3 Players do not receive priority during the night phase

9.5.4 No cards may be played and no abilities may be activated unless a specific effect allows it

Once all effects have resolved, the next player's turn begins with the morning phase.

This phase ends after all state-based checks and pending effects have been resolved

10. Marker Rules

In Athernium: The Old World, markers, counters, and tokens represent persistent game modifications or temporary elements that interact with permanents, players, and zones. This chapter defines their types, usage, and behavior during gameplay

10.0.1 **Markers** refer collectively to tokens, counters and similar indicators that remain on a permanent to track a game-related state. They do not encompass tokens as an instance of a permanent or attachment

10.0.2 **Tokens** – as used in this chapter – are elements used to represent abstract game resources (e.g., Command Tokens) or to track non-numerical progression (e.g., Victory Tokens). They are not considered permanents and do not occupy game zones

10.0.3 **Counters** are numeric or status markers placed directly onto permanents. They represent a lasting condition, such as damage or exhaustion

All markers, counters, and tokens defined in this chapter are treated equally:

10.0.4 Only permanents can have markers, counters or tokens. Cards in secondary zones such as the hand, discard pile, the void, deck or extra deck cannot gain or retain markers

10.0.5 Markers, tokens and counters are removed if their host permanent changes zones

10.0.6 No marker, token or counter may move across zones. If an effect attempts to do so, it fails

10.0.7 A marker, token or counter remains visible on a face-down or exhausted permanent

10.1.0 Victory Tokens

Victory Tokens are placed onto cards with a Victory Token Field to track a player's progress toward winning the game. These tokens are drawn from a shared global pool

10.1.1 The initial pool contains a number of tokens equal to the sum of the number printed on the Victory Token Field of all main characters

10.1.2 When a permanent with a Victory Token Field enters the game board, the global pool increases by the number printed on or defined by the effect that created the permanent

10.1.3 Victory Tokens may only be placed on a permanent with a Victory Token Field

10.1.4 When a Victory Token is placed onto a permanent, it is removed from the global pool

10.1.5 If a Victory Token is removed from a permanent, it is returned to the global pool

10.1.6 If an effect causes a Victory Token to be lost, it is removed from the game

10.1.7 Players may not place more Victory Tokens than are available in the global pool

10.2.0 Command Tokens

Command Tokens are a limited personal resource used to activate Command Abilities

10.2.1 At the beginning of each turn, the active player's Command Token supply is replenished to its maximum value

10.2.2 The default maximum is 2 Command Tokens

10.2.3 Additional Command Tokens may not exceed this maximum unless a rule or effect increases it

10.2.4 Command Tokens are spent as part of the activation cost of a Command Ability

10.2.5 Unspent Command Tokens are retained between turns unless removed by an effect

Command Tokens are not part of the resource pool and cannot be converted or exchanged for other values

10.3.0 Damage Counters

Damage Counters represent damage dealt to a permanent with a Defensive Value (DFV)

10.3.1 A permanent may receive damage counters as a result of combat or effects.

10.3.2 Damage counters may only be placed on permanents possessing a Defensive Value (DFV)

10.3.2a Permanents that are face-down or exhausted but are known to possess a DFV, or could possess one based on their card type or rules context, are also legal targets for damage counters

10.3.3 If the number of damage counters on a face-up permanent equals or exceeds its current Defensive Value, it is discarded during the next state-based check

10.3.4 Damage counters may be added, removed, or modified by effects

Damage counters do not expire unless removed

10.4.0 Exhaustion Counters

Exhaustion Counters track whether a permanent is exhausted or subject to exhaustion-based effects

10.4.1 An Exhaustion Counter is placed on a permanent when it becomes exhausted

10.4.2 Exhausted permanents are turned face-down and lose all abilities, Offensive and Defensive Values, and subtypes

10.4.3 An Exhaustion Counter does not, by itself, exhaust a card. A card with an Exhaustion Counter is not necessarily exhausted

10.4.4 Effects may place, remove, or modify Exhaustion Counters directly

10.4.5 Exhaustion ends when all Exhaustion Counters are removed, during the Morning Phase or by an effect

Exhaustion Counters remain visible even if the permanent is face-down

10.5.0 Custom Marker Types

Certain cards and effects may create or reference custom marker types (e.g., Poison, Corruption, Seal). These follow the same general rules as standard markers but may include additional effects or behaviors

10.5.1 A custom marker type must be clearly defined in card text or in the Comprehensive Rules

10.5.2 Custom markers that are not defined by the rules must include explanatory text on the card that creates them

10.5.3 A marker type defined by the rules does not require explanation on the card or effect that creates it

10.5.4 Custom markers may be subject to specific interactions, such as accumulation thresholds or conversion effects

If a card refers to a marker type not otherwise defined, that marker exists but has no game effect unless one is given

11. Tournament Rules

Organized play in Athernum: The Old World provides a structured and competitive environment for players to test their strategies and deck-building skills. This chapter outlines the official tournament rules and standards currently applicable, with Constructed as the primary supported format

11.0.1 Tournament organizers may structure events as Main Events, Side Events, or Casual Tournaments, depending on scope and participation

11.0.1a Unless stated otherwise, all rules in this chapter apply to every official tournament regardless of its structure

11.0.2 **Constructed** is the primary tournament format. Each Constructed deck must follow the rules below:

11.0.2a A deck must contain exactly 60 cards

11.0.2b Each deck must include at least one card with a Victory Token Field that is eligible to begin the game according to the standard game rules

11.0.2c Players may bring a separate Extra Deck containing up to 20 additional cards. These cards are not part of the main deck but may be referenced or summoned by card effects

11.0.2d No more than four copies of any single card may be included across both the main deck and the Extra Deck, unless explicitly stated otherwise on the card

11.0.2e Tokens, faction resources, and visual markers may be brought in addition to the Extra Deck and are not counted toward the 20-card limit

11.0.3 The official game board defines the spatial arrangement of all primary zones and slots during a match. This layout ensures visual clarity and consistent application of rule terms such as “linked” and “adjacent”

11.0.3a Character Slots are located along the upper edge of the game board. Each player area contains exactly five Character Slots arranged in a single horizontal row from left to right

11.0.3b Directly to the right of the rightmost Character Slot is the Main Character Slot. This slot is reserved for the chosen Main Character and is considered part of the Character row for all rule purposes

11.0.3c To the right of the Main Character Slot is the Location Slot. The Location Slot may be slightly offset in position, as long as it remains visually clear that it could link to the Main Character Slot

11.0.3d Beneath the Character and Main Character Slots lies the Item Zone, reserved for Item Slots created or provided by permanents. This zone maintains the vertical alignment between items and their linked permanents above

11.0.3e Directly below the Item Zone is the Resource Zone, where Resource Tokens and other value markers are placed. This zone represents the player's active source of resources and associated permanents

11.0.3f The Deck, Discard Pile, and Void may be positioned either to the left or right side of the main play area, provided they are clearly distinguishable and do not overlap any active game zones

11.0.3g Officially approved playmats must follow this general structure. Minor deviations in size, design, or alignment are acceptable as long as the relative positioning of all zones remains consistent and gameplay clarity is maintained

11.0.3h Any deviation from this layout during tournament play is considered an improper setup and must be corrected before the match begins

11.0.4 When using a playmat, it must be positioned in a way that aligns the Main Character Slot and all five Character Slots of each player directly to those of their opponents

11.0.4a The Main Character Slot is considered to lie directly opposite an opponent's leftmost Character Slot

11.0.4b This alignment is required to ensure correct interaction of Linked Zones, especially when a permanent establishes links across opposing zones

11.0.4c Any deviation from this alignment during tournament play is considered an improper setup and must be corrected before the match begins

11.1.0 Match Rules

All tournament matches are played as Best-of-3

11.1.1 After completing the initial setup, there is no redraw. Players must play with their initial starting hand

11.1.2 The initiative values of the selected main character determine which player goes first

11.1.3 Each match has a 50-minute time limit

If the time limit is reached before a winner is determined:

11.1.4 The current turn is completed

11.1.5 Each player receives one additional turn

11.1.6 After both extra turns, the player with the most Victory Tokens wins the match

11.1.7 If both players have the same number of Victory Tokens, the match is a draw

11.2.0 Card Legality and Banned Lists

11.2.1 All officially published cards are considered legal for tournament play unless explicitly banned by official rules

11.2.2 An up-to-date ban list is maintained externally and may be updated at any time

11.2.3 Tournament organizers may add additional restrictions or bans for specific events

11.2.3a These must be clearly announced and publicly available before the event begins

11.3.0 Code of Conduct

All players are expected to treat opponents, judges, and all game materials with respect

11.3.1 Players have to handle other players property with care

11.3.2 Players may not touch or move another player's cards, tokens, or components without explicit permission

11.3.3 Cheating, deception, or deliberate rule violations (e.g., using unregistered or banned cards, slow play) are not tolerated

11.3.4 Spectators are not allowed to communicate with players during a match

11.3.4a Any form of outside assistance is strictly prohibited and may result in penalties for the involved player

11.3.4b Any player may call for a judge to prevent minding into the game

11.3.5 At the end of each match, players must report the result to a judge or tournament official

11.3.5a Both players are responsible for verifying the accuracy of the result

Penalties for rule violations:

11.3.6 **First offense:** If an illegal game state is detected, a formal warning is given and the judge will attempt to restore the game to the most recent legal state

11.3.6a If this is not possible, the judge may rule in favor of one player or issue a draw

11.3.7 **Second offense:** Immediate match loss

Judges' decisions are final. Any ongoing argument or refusal to comply with rulings results in immediate disqualification from the tournament

11.4.0 Registration, Companion App and Online Integration

Players must submit a complete deck list before the start of the event

11.4.1 The deck must match the list exactly

11.4.2 Any additions (e.g., the Extra Deck) must be visible on that list

11.4.3 For in-person events, physical registration using an official paper form with a deck list is valid

11.4.3a In this case, cards do not need to be registered to a player's account

11.4.3b Tournament organizers may also offer online registration, but are not required to do so

11.4.4 Discrepancies may result in penalties or disqualification

Players may register for official tournaments through the Companion App

11.4.5 Online registration is only possible using cards registered to the player's account

11.4.5a An official printed card always carries a unique ID given as QR-Code

11.4.5b The QR-Code of an unused card should be covered by a thin layer. *(Note: If that layer is partially scratched or has been removed, the card might have already been registered by another account. Any player should*

keep this in mind when acquiring used cards)

11.4.5c The QR-Code – once the covering layer is removed – can be scanned by an appropriate device using the official Companion App

11.4.6 Online tournaments follow the same rules as in-person events

11.4.7 Misuse of the digital platform, falsified card lists, or attempts to manipulate results lead to immediate disqualification

12. Special Rules and Clarifications

While the core rules of Athernum: The Old World cover most interactions and gameplay scenarios, some cards and game effects introduce unique behaviors or override standard procedures. This chapter provides a framework for managing such exceptions and clarifies any fringe cases that may arise during advanced gameplay or card interactions

12.1.0 Rule Clarifications

This subsection will contain interpretations or decisions that clarify the application of specific core rules in rare or unusual situations. As the card pool and mechanical complexity of the game expand, this section will be updated accordingly

12.2.0 Extra Rules

Certain cards feature an Extra Rule field that introduces exceptional rules overriding or modifying the standard game system. These rules are listed here for reference and clarification. Only Extra Rules appearing on officially released cards are included

12.2.A Unique

12.2.Aa A card with the “Unique” rule may only be included once per deck

12.2.Ab This restriction overrides the general deck-building rule that allows up to four copies of any card. Only one copy of a unique card may be included across both the main deck and the Extra Deck